

## ***The Insertion Point***

An important concept when dealing with any kind of text is the insertion point, which we mentioned in passing in the last chapter. As we noted in that chapter, the mouse cursor changes to an I-beam when it's positioned over a text entry area. Clicking the mouse when it's in a text area moves the insertion point to the cursor position.

So what's the insertion point, anyway? It's a second cursor that's independent of the location of the mouse cursor. The insertion point moves when you type and when you click the mouse on a section of text, as opposed to moving whenever you move the mouse. The insertion point keeps track of where the next key you press will be inserted into your text.

The arrow keys can also be used to move the insertion point around. Additionally, holding down ⌘ and pressing the left or right arrow key moves the insertion point to the beginning or end of the current line; using Option with the left and right arrow keys moves the insertion point to the beginning of the next or previous word.

## ***Selecting Text***

To select one or more characters for editing, drag the I-beam cursor across the characters you want to select. (Remember, in the Apple Desktop you first select the object you want to work with—in this case, some text—then you tell the computer what you want to do. Object-action, remember?)

For example, if you want to select the word "her" inside the word "there," you'd first position the I-beam to the left of the letter "h," then press the mouse button and drag across the letters "her" until all three of them are displayed as white letters on a black background. When this happens, release the mouse button. The letters "her" are now selected for editing. (You can also drag backward; the result is the same.)

You can also shift-click to select a section of text from the insertion point to the mouse cursor position. For example, if the insertion point were already to the left of the letter "h," you could simply shift-click after "r" to select "her."

### **Note!**

When selecting multiple lines of text, the selection moves rightward first, then downward. For example, if you click in the middle of the first line of text and drag down to the middle of the third line of text, you have selected the right half of the first line, the entire second line, and the left half of the third line. By the way, most word processing programs will automatically scroll if your selection runs into the edge of the window.

Shift-clicking is also used to extend or contract a selection. If you've already selected text and realize you want to select more (or less) text, hold down the shift key and click the I-beam where you want the selection to end. The selection will grow or shrink as appropriate to where you clicked.